



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Our Savior Lutheran School
School Website: <https://www.oslsgr.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) or the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Our Savior Lutheran School (OSLS) in Grand Rapids, MI clearly presents a classical Christian program anchored in Lutheran catechesis. Across six core categories, OSLS demonstrates core classical commitments: a theology-centered foundation with liturgical practices; formation of virtue and wisdom as the telos of education; a curriculum built on the liberal arts, Great Books, and Western civilization; pedagogy that blends contemplative/restful approaches with Socratic dialogue, rhetoric, and memorization; a faculty culture oriented toward virtue and mentorship; and a robust partnership with parents and an open, family-friendly community orientation. The materials consistently emphasize truth, goodness, and beauty as real and knowable, the centrality of Scripture, and the aim of forming a virtuous, well-educated human being rather than simply training for work. The Great Books and liberal-arts framing, combined with liturgical practice and explicit formation aims, align OSLS with a classical rubric.

Overall classification: CLASSICAL.

- **Religious and Metaphysical Foundations:** OSLS grounds its program in Scripture and Lutheran confession, with daily worship and catechesis, and a liturgical, communal rhythm. Evidence: explicit statements about the Word of God shaping daily instruction, worship, catechetical recitations, Lutheran hymnody, and centrality of Scripture.
- **Purpose and Goal:** The school foregrounds formation, virtue, wisdom, and enduring truths (truth, goodness, beauty) over mere job-readiness. Evidence: formation-focused language, emphasis on virtue and wisdom, and Great-Books framing.
- **Curriculum:** Liberal arts core (grammar, logic, rhetoric) plus Great Books and Western civilization; history across the curriculum; emphasis on wonder. Evidence: explicit listing of the seven liberal arts; Great Books; reading and analysis of literature; pursuit of wonder.
- **Pedagogy:** Blends contemplative/restful learning with Socratic discussion, memory work, and rhetoric; lower grades include singing/chanting; upper grades incorporate seminars and oratory. Evidence: Socratic questioning; memory/recitation; rhetoric training; singing/chapel integration.
- **Faculty:** Implied model-teacher/mentorship orientation with emphasis on virtue and formation; teachers as partners with parents; emphasis on "living curriculum." Evidence: language about forming students through virtuous teaching; collaboration with parents; emphasis on virtue in teacher-student interactions.
- **Parents & Community:** Explicit partnership with parents; openness to visits; parental formation opportunities; emphasis on parents as co-partners in formation. Evidence: "work closely with parents," "Visit Us" information, invitations for family engagement.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Daily all-school worship, Scripture recitations, catechetical instruction, Lutheran hymnody, and a central place for Holy Scriptures in daily life. - The Word of God is described as a constant presence shaping instruction and culture; theology and confessional teaching are foundational. - Public materials state the school is rooted in Lutheran catechesis and confessions, with a liturgical, sacred rhythm to the day.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present (example list): theology, liturgy, worship, Scripture, catechesis, Holy Scriptures, Lutheran Confessions, Word of God, hymnody, prayer, sacred tradition. These align with the Positive Keyword indicators for this category in the Six Essential Elements lexicon. (Core terms appear in OSLS materials and are echoed in the “We Are/Who We Are” pages and Faith statements.) See sources above. - Negative keywords present: none detected in current materials (no explicit secular, relativistic, or value-neutral framing).

Why this rating - OSLS centers theology, liturgy, and sacred Scripture as core to daily life and learning; communal worship and catechesis anchor the entire educational program. This strongly satisfies the Religious and Metaphysical Foundations criteria for CLASSICAL.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Explicit aim: formation of virtue and wisdom, not merely information or career preparation. - Framing around truth, goodness, and beauty as real and knowable, with a view toward human flourishing and moral formation. - Great Books and a Western-civilization-centered formation are described as core elements of the education, consonant with the classical telos.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, truth, goodness, beauty, great conversation, Great Books, Western civilization, human flourishing. - Negative keywords present: none evident (no emphasis on job-readiness or workforce metrics in public materials).

Why this rating - The program’s stated telos is the cultivation of character and wisdom through a perennial-forms framework (virtue, truth, beauty) rather than utilitarian job training, aligning with CLASSICAL criteria.

Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Explicit liberal-arts core: grammar, logic, rhetoric (with mentions of mathematics, music, geometry, astronomy). - History is treated as a through-line across the curriculum, with references to Great Books and Western civilization. - Emphasis on reading and analysis of good literature, ancient languages, and Great Books as part of the “Great Conversation.” - Education aims to cultivate wonder and the experience of the true, good, and beautiful.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: liberal arts, grammar, logic, rhetoric, Great Books, Western civilization, literature, ancient languages, Great Conversation, wonder, formation through the arts. - Negative keywords present: none (the public materials foreground history-as-history, not social studies, which aligns with classical framing rather than a secular social-studies emphasis).

Why this rating - The curriculum is squarely framed around the liberal-arts canon, Great Books, and the “Great Conversation,” aligned with classical standards.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Emphasis on contemplative/restful learning (Scholé) and memorization/recitation; lower-school singing and memory work; regular review and chant as memory-building practices. - Upper-school pedagogy includes Socratic discussion, seminars, debates, and opportunities to develop rhetoric through speeches. - The school notes that some education should be contemplative and restful, while upper grades engage in rigorous dialectic and rhetorical training.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: Scholé, Socratic dialogue, dialectic, seminars, rhetoric, memorization/recitation, chanting, oral discourse, great conversation, formation through imitation. - Negative keywords present: none noted (no emphasis on purely project-based or student-directed constructivism that would signal departure from classical pedagogy).

Why this rating - OSLS demonstrates a dual-track pedagogy: restful, memory-based practices in earlier grades and Socratic/rhetorical methods in later grades, consistent with classical pedagogy models.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The program describes teachers as virtuous, well-formed guides who model virtue and knowledge, and who partner with parents to shape student formation. - Framing of the classroom as a “living curriculum” and teachers as mentors within a community emphasizing virtue and thoughtful instruction. The site emphasizes the teacher-student relationship as foundational to learning and character formation. - The school highlights the teachers’ role in guiding students through liberal-arts study, close reading, and disciplined inquiry, aligned with classical formation.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: living curriculum, model teachers, mentors, virtue, guidance, masterful instruction, close reading, disciplined inquiry, collaboration with parents. - Negative keywords present: none explicitly present in OSLS public materials (no “facilitator-only” or non-classical teacher labels).

Why this rating - The materials describe teachers as central, virtuous guides who shape character and intellect, with a strong emphasis on mentorship and classical formation, supporting CLASSICAL status for Faculty.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - OSLS emphasizes partnership with parents and collaboration to shape heart and habits; frequent parent involvement and clear channels for engagement (visits, admissions, communications). - Public materials invite families to visit, learn, and participate in the school community; the school positions itself as a community that welcomes parental involvement. - The school documents reflect a family-centric model where parents are engaged in formation, and schools provide opportunities for parental education and gatherings.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with parents, co-teachers, parental formation, parent involvement, family engagement, open campus/visits, book studies (implied by the culture of formation and gatherings). - Negative keywords present: none (no consumer-facing or minimal-involvement language; the model is partnership-based).

Why this rating - OSLS explicitly frames parents as co-participants in formation and invites active parental involvement and education, aligning with CLASSICAL expectations for Parents & Community.

What Would Move the Needle

- Given the CLASSICAL classification across all six categories, no major needle-moving changes are required. Minor enhancements could include explicitly naming the “living curriculum” concept in the public materials for Faculty (to reinforce the living-teacher ethos) and adding a concise, school-wide articulation of “parent as co-teacher” language in admissions and about pages to tighten the alignment with classical-parent partnership vocabulary. These would be clarifications rather than policy shifts.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

By reading or using this document, you acknowledge and accept the limitations described above.